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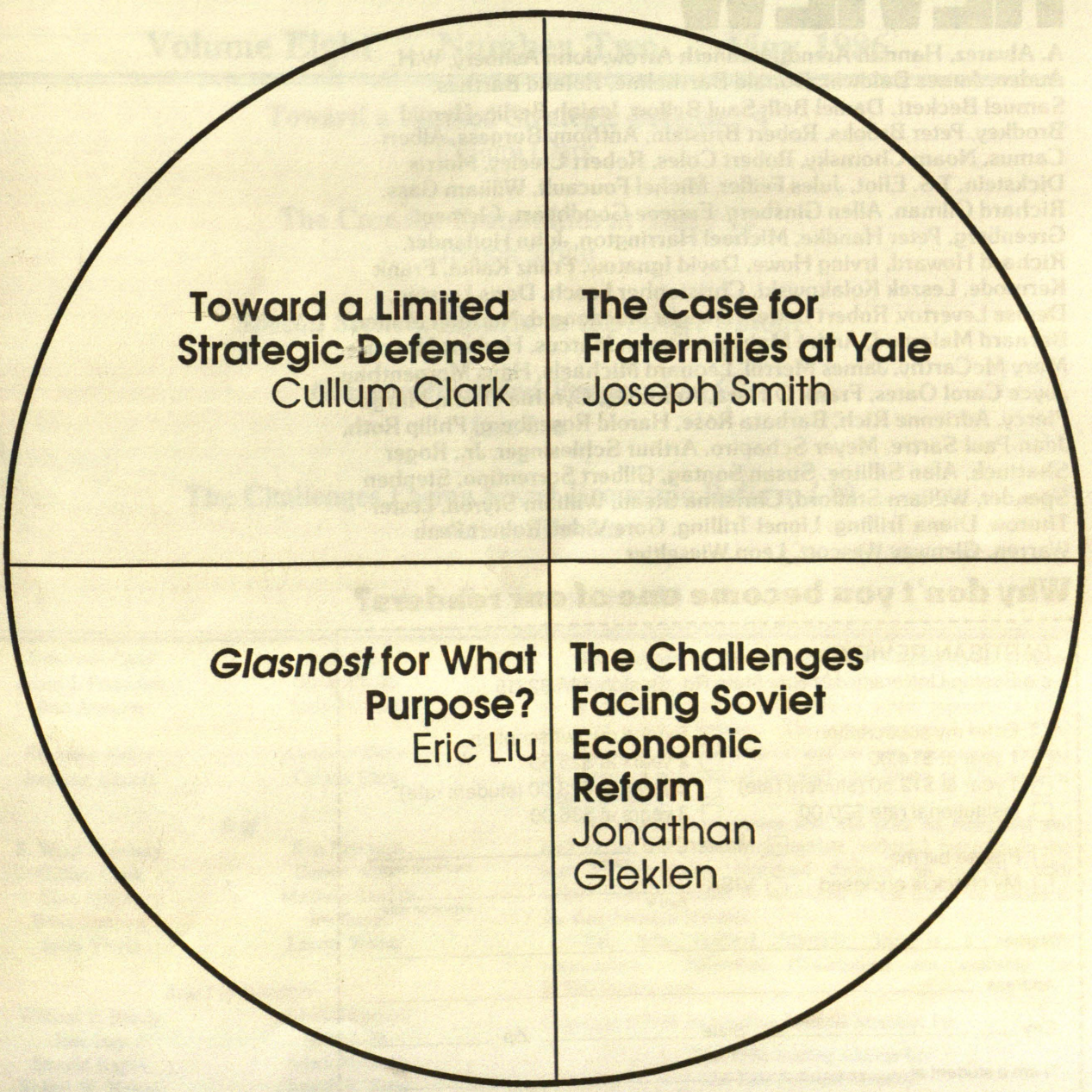
Commencement Issue



Toward a Limited Strategic Defense
Cullum Clark

The Case for Fraternities at Yale
Joseph Smith

***Glasnost* for What Purpose?**
Eric Liu

The Challenges Facing Soviet Economic Reform
Jonathan Gleklen

Plus: Letters & Comments

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Toward a Limited Strategic Defense

Cullum Clark

The debate over the President's Strategic Defense Initiative (SDI) is now entering a critical phase. A series of recent events have thrust the question of ballistic missile defense into stark relief, and the decisions reached in the next few months will shape the nation's defense strategy and arms control efforts for decades to come. For President Reagan's uncompromising devotion to SDI, popularly known as 'Star Wars,' now appears to be the main obstacle to an unprecedented nuclear arms control agreement, along the lines bandied about between Reagan and Soviet leader Mikhail Gorbachev at the Reykjavik summit in October. Moreover, the Administration's new 'broad interpretation' of the 1972 Anti-Ballistic Missile (ABM) Treaty — an interpretation that would legalize the next stage of SDI — threatens to destroy the treaty altogether. And the Soviet Union is now ending its unilateral 18-month moratorium on nuclear tests, a move which may portend a new escalation of the arms race. Clearly, the concept of strategic defense demands urgent examination.

Strategic defense is nothing new; the notion of building defensive systems to locate and destroy an enemy's ballistic missiles in flight dates back to the 1960s, when the Johnson and Nixon Administrations began the 'Safeguard' ABM system as a limited defense of population centers and offensive missile sites (an idea that was nipped in the bud by the ABM Treaty). What is new, however, is the rhetoric attached to SDI. When President Reagan announced the program on March 23, 1983, he called for an impenetrable shield that would, in his words, render nuclear weapons "impotent and obsolete." The unfortunate effect of this grandiose dream was to draw the lines of the debate precisely according to the President's terms: either we would build a defense that would end the nuclear peril forever or we would build no defense at all. The vast intellectual space between was abandoned, save for a handful of well-informed legislators and Pentagon strategists. All eyes invariably focused on the dream of the Great Communicator. It is the purpose of this article to explore the largely unoccupied middle of the debate: the position that strategic defense cannot achieve the goals set out for it by the President's SDI but can nonetheless make a valuable contribution to the nation's security and to the prevention of nuclear war.

Ronald Reagan no doubt sincerely believes in his dream; the trouble is that almost no one else does. For an SDI system, space-based or otherwise, to render nuclear weapons "impotent and obsolete," it must be able to (1) locate and track the trajectories of as many as 20,000 incoming Soviet warheads in a matter of minutes; (2) distinguish between actual warheads and the thousands of balloons, metal scraps, and other 'penetration aids' that would accompany them; (3) destroy *all* the warheads (remember that even one nuclear explosion in a major city is not an acceptable failure rate); and (4) defend *itself*, so that it is not destroyed before it has done its job. Finally, it must all work the first time it is tested. According to the vast majority of strategists, physicists and commentators who have considered the question, this perfect 'astrodome' cannot be achieved.

Critics of SDI present a bevy of technical complaints; four will suffice. First, the technology necessary to achieve this immense feat simply will not exist in the foreseeable future. One physicist estimated that an SDI even remotely like that proposed by the President would require the solution of eight different physical and engineering problems each more difficult than the Manhattan Project's invention of the atomic bomb. Defense Secretary Caspar Weinberger counters that a successful test over the Kwajalein Atoll in

Cullum Clark is a sophomore in Branford College and Associate Editor of YPM.

September of last year proved the technology is within reach. But this test involved the interception of but one moving object, a far cry from 20,000, and the defense system did not have to worry about defending itself. The leakproof shield is at best a very long way off.

Second, any potential system could be overwhelmed by sheer numbers of offensive warheads. Consider an analogy of 'successful' strategic defense SDI proponents like to draw: the defense of Britain against German bombers in 1940-41. By shooting down at most a quarter of the planes in each raid, the British eventually, after hundreds of raids, crippled the Luftwaffe. *But three-quarters of the bombs in every raid got through.* Now even if an SDI system attains 95 percent effectiveness (which is extremely unlikely), 1000 Soviet warheads would still arrive on target. That would be enough to annihilate every American city of at least 10,000 people. What's more, the Soviets could easily raise the number of successful warheads by building more beforehand — something which is very much within their capabilities now.

Third, virtually all experts agree that no SDI system could successfully defend *itself* against a determined Soviet attack before a general nuclear strike. If only a few of the system's all-important battle-management radars in space were destroyed, it would be the defensive system, not the missiles, that would be rendered "impotent." Even so ardent an SDI proponent as Paul Nitze, a presidential arms control adviser, says we should build no system that is not reasonably likely to survive a determined attack. When Defense Secretary Caspar Weinberger disapprovingly alludes to the Cassandras who once declared that mankind could not travel to the moon, more sober-minded analysts answer correctly that the moon did not fight back.

Fourth, and most obviously, if the Soviets ever want to destroy our cities, they don't need ballistic missiles to do it. Laser guns and particle-beams high in space cannot stop low-flying bombers, cruise-missiles or low-trajectory missiles launched from submarines just off our coastline — all of which the Soviets have and would surely use to foil an SDI 'shield.' So former Secretary of Defense Harold Brown, himself a prominent physicist, is right to conclude, "Technology does not offer even a reasonable prospect of a successful population defense... Both the United States and the Soviet Union will be able to undertake successful countermeasures against any system intended to defend urban-industrial centers and their populations — however many the layers of defense."

Strange as it seems, even leading members of the President's own administration deny that his dream can be achieved. According to defense analysts Michael Mandelbaum and Strobe Talbott, "Virtually his entire government either ha[s] abandoned the idea of a comprehensive defense that would make traditional deterrence unnecessary or ha[s] never subscribed to the idea in the first place." And in the words of Lieutenant General James Abrahamson, who heads the SDI program, "A perfect astrodome defense is not a realistic thing."

Faced with the inescapable conclusion that strategic defense cannot and will not protect our cities from a massive Soviet attack, must we dispense with the idea altogether, as many critics would have us do? Certainly not, for strategic defense can serve other purposes that are both worthwhile and attainable. First, a defensive system could defend against small nuclear attacks, either accidental launches or deliberate strikes by small nuclear powers. The former are an inherent risk of the nuclear age, and the latter will become increasingly conceivable as leaders like Libya's Colonel Gadhafi continue their quest for nuclear weapons. The Safeguard ABM was devised in large part to meet these threats.

Second, American interest in strategic defense can, in certain circumstances, contribute to arms control. No matter how repellant the idea of the 'bargaining chip' is to many liberals, it is undeniable that SDI has helped to bring General Secretary Gorbachev to the negotiating table. For this reason alone, we should continue at least some work on defensive systems.

Third, and most important, strategic defense could protect our land-based nuclear missiles from attack, thereby insuring America's ability to retaliate for any Soviet nuclear strike. A far less glamorous goal than the President's, this capability is nevertheless the centerpiece of nuclear deterrence: the Soviets will be extremely unlikely to launch a nuclear attack against the United States so long as they know the US can retaliate in kind. This, in fact, is the objective for SDI explicitly put forward by Assistant Secretary of Defense Richard Perle, the Administration's foremost spokesman on strategic issues.

There is currently a great deal of dispute over whether our retaliatory forces are truly in danger. Conservative groups like the Committee on the Present Danger have asserted that we face a 'window of vulnerability,' in which the recent Soviet offensive buildup has made it possible for them to destroy our entire Intercontinental Ballistic Missile (ICBM) force, as well as our approximately 200 launch control centers, in a surprise first strike. Whether this danger is in fact 'present' is unclear, but the thrust of the conservatives' argument is undeniable: as the Soviets increase both the number and accuracy of their offensive warheads, our land-based forces will become more vulnerable. Already the Soviets can aim approximately 6000 ICBM warheads at 1200 ICBM silos and launch-

control centers, and their new SS-X-24 and SS-X-25 mobile ICBMs will be vastly more accurate than their current inventory.

Skeptics point out that, even with our ICBM force destroyed, we would retain our submarine and bomber-based retaliatory weapons, a fact which, they argue, surely deters Soviet action alone. But ICBM vulnerability remains a dangerous threat, for four reasons. The first is that submarines and bombers could become less effective in the future because of Soviet technological breakthroughs in anti-submarine warfare and air defense. Second, our submarine retaliatory threat could be paralyzed in an attack if the land-based command authorities and communications facilities were, to use strategic jargon, 'decapitated' and thus rendered incapable of ordering a retaliatory strike. Third, the Soviets could be tempted, in an acute crisis, to destroy our ICBM forces and then hold our cities 'hostage,' threatening their devastation if we retaliated. Finally, American officials aware of the vulnerability of their ICBM forces would be extremely reluctant to lose them, and might in a political crisis be more likely to launch them simply on the warning of a Soviet attack, or even pre-emptively. This 'use them or lose them' syndrome would be extremely destabilizing, and could even result in a 1914-like war, in which neither side could afford to let the other side attack first. Protection of our retaliatory ICBM forces, then, is a worthwhile objective for strategic defense.

But SDI, as President Reagan envisions it, is not necessary for defense against small nuclear attacks and protection of US retaliatory forces. While the 'astrodome' defense of the President's dreams would require the multilayered, space-based system currently under consideration (and more), these more limited objectives could be met with a much simpler set-up. Such a system would be completely or primarily land-based, and it would intercept incoming warheads only in the 'terminal phase' of their trajectory — once they reenter the atmosphere — not in all phases as SDI would attempt. It would include hardened land-based radars and nuclear-tipped interceptor missiles, like the Sprint and Spartan missiles we now have, or the ERIS and HEDI missiles under development. It would provide only 'hard-point' defense, which means it would be located only around small, reinforced targets like ICBM silos, launch control centers, and bunkers for the national command authorities, and would offer a reasonable chance of survival only to these installations.

Unlike the vastly more elaborate SDI, such a system is a technical possibility. It could even be built in the next decade, and it could be improved as radar and non-nuclear missile technology advances. According to Harold Brown, "It is technologically feasible to create a *terminal defense* overlay of hard ICBM silos, deployed so that their position at any one time is unknown to the attacker. Such a defense overlay can, by preferential defense — that is, defending only the occupied silos — provide a cost-exchange ratio favorable to the defense because the attacker must attack all silos....In the case of hard-silo defense, a single layer of defense by endoatmospheric ground-based interceptors would suffice." Brown goes on, "The necessary technology exists now, and some subsystems have already been partially developed."

A limited, terminal-phase-only, point defense would contribute to American security in two ways: it would preserve our ability to retaliate, thereby reducing the risk of nuclear war, and it would save millions of people should war occur.

Limited defense would eliminate the 'window of vulnerability' problem, now and in the future, by creating profound uncertainty in the mind of any Soviet leader contemplating an attack. The Soviets henceforth would face the probability that many American ICBMs would survive a first strike, and they would therefore be less likely to order an attack in an acute crisis. Of course, such a defense would be far from leakproof; many of the incoming warheads in an attack would get through it. But the uncertainty it would provoke just might make the crucial difference in a moment of high tension. As former Secretary of State Henry Kissinger put it, "Anything that magnifies doubt inspires hesitation. The case grows stronger if one considers the defense of Intercontinental Ballistic Missile launchers... The incentive for a first strike would be sharply, perhaps decisively, reduced if an aggressor knew that half of the opponent's ICBMs would survive any foreseeable attack."

Critics of strategic defense contend that we can maintain ICBM invulnerability in other, cheaper ways. One simple answer, some assert, is offensive arms control: If we can just reach an agreement with the Soviets reducing offensive weaponry on both sides, it is thought, then they will not have enough missiles left to threaten our ICBM forces. But the current Geneva efforts are a slim reed on which to rest our security. For one thing, the deal now in the making would only limit each side to 6000 strategic warheads — more than enough to attack our 1200 land-based targets, especially with new improvements in missile accuracy. It is by no means clear that the Soviets would agree to lower numbers, Gorbachev's dramatic pronouncements notwithstanding. Moreover, to trust arms control *alone* is to leave our fate in Soviet hands; we would have no way to answer a rapid Soviet breakout from our agreed arms limits. To be sure, offensive arms control can, if well conceived, enhance the security of both sides, but it provides no answer to our ICBM vulnerability problem.

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The best alternative to strategic defense put forward so far would be to build mobile missiles, particularly the 'Midgetman,' that would move about on trucks or railways. Mobile basing is undoubtedly a good idea; but it should be a complement to, not a substitute for, strategic defense. Even mobile ICBMs could ultimately become vulnerable, if the Soviets were able to improve their tracking technology and build maneuverable warheads (which are not that far off) for their next generation of offensive weapons. If the missiles moved about on a track, the entire area — if it were undefended — could be overwhelmed by great numbers of attacking warheads. The *combination* of mobile basing and strategic point defense, however, would vastly complicate Soviet planning, and that complication is precisely what enhances deterrence best.

A limited defense would protect not only missiles but people as well. This is not to say that it could defend against an all-out attack on our cities: if the Soviets really want to destroy our cities, there is nothing we can do to stop them. But if the Soviets ever launch a first strike, it will not be against our cities; it will be a 'counterforce' strike on our missiles, launch control centers, and national command and communications centers. To do otherwise would be suicidal. But such an attack, some experts have estimated, would kill as many as 20 million Americans, largely as a result of the radioactivity released by so many explosions. A terminal phase defense, by destroying many of the incoming warheads in the upper reaches of the atmosphere, would drastically reduce the amount of radiation in the atmosphere at ground level. It is impossible to predict how many people would be saved, but even two or three million should warrant an investment in a limited strategic defense. True, this would be no leakproof astrodome, but it would save a lot of innocent people in the most likely form of nuclear war.

Whatever the President's SDI could realistically achieve, then, a limited strategic defense could achieve just as well, and a lot more cost-efficiently too. But a ground-based terminal point defense would also avoid the negative side of SDI: its destabilizion of the strategic balance, its disastrous effect on arms control, and its divisiveness in the Western alliance.

To begin with, even if an SDI system were far from the leakproof shield it is cracked up to be, it would destabilize the strategic relationship between the superpowers, raising the risk of nuclear war. The space-based 'Star Wars' defense envisioned by the Reagan Administration would introduce a Pandora's Box of new threats to Soviet security that would keep even the most confident Soviet strategist up at night, scrambling for solutions.

First among these, as General Secretary Gorbachev has repeatedly stressed, an SDI population defense could back up highly accurate new American missiles like the MX to give the United States an unprecedented first-strike capability. The reasoning runs as follows: SDI might not be very effective against a Soviet first strike, but if the US struck first, destroying most of the Soviet Union's strategic forces, the SDI defense might be able to stop nearly all of the small, ragged Soviet retaliatory force that remained. Damage to the American homeland would thus be minimal. One might discount the possibility of our launching a first strike, but it is nonetheless conceivable that, in a crisis, our defensive shield might give an American president just enough confidence to risk an attack — especially if he thought the Soviets were about to attack anyway.

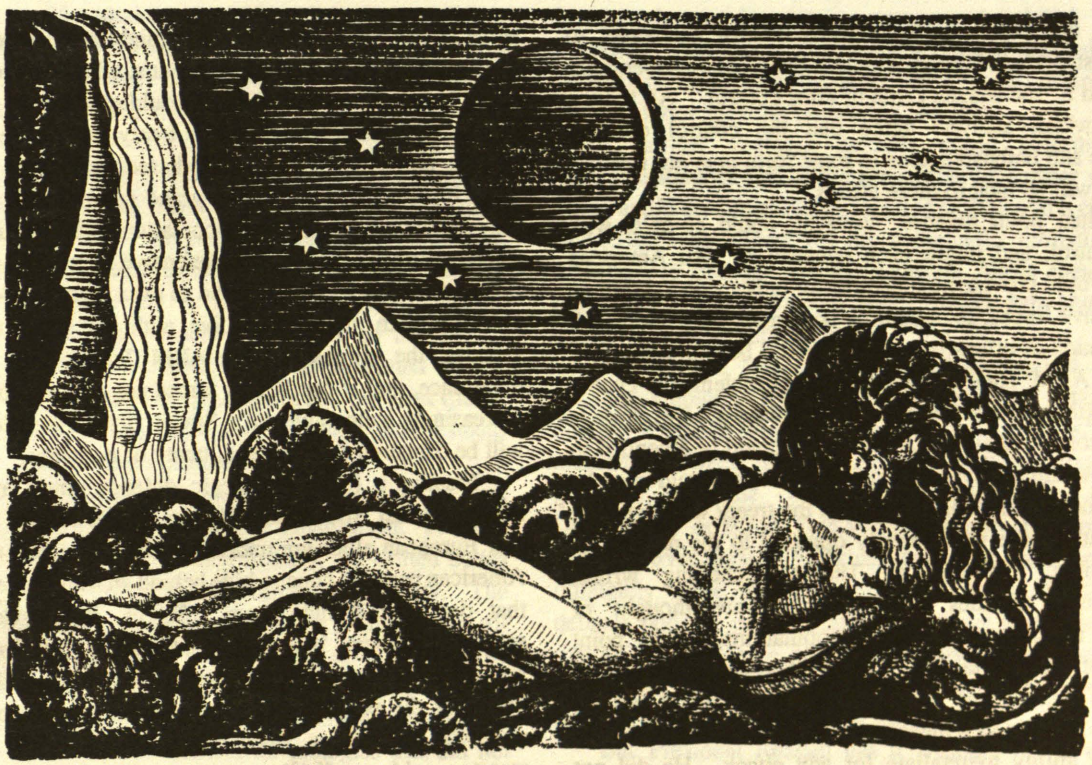
Second, even if one assumes that we would never have the Machiavellian ruthlessness to strike first, the Soviets might *think* we did. The very existence of our hypothetical SDI-backed first-strike threat would make the Soviet leaders ever more touchy, ever more ready to assume the worst and therefore order a pre-emptive attack in a crisis. We should avoid any program that promotes this kind of instability, for this is probably the most likely form a nuclear war would take.

Third, the proposed SDI program could potentially become a direct *offensive* weapon in a first-strike scenario. It could be used to destroy Soviet tracking satellites, or its speed-of-light lasers could even be used for a lightning attack on Soviet ICBM silos. Afterall, attacking missiles still on the ground is not very different from attacking them just after they take off, which is what the President proposes to do.

Fourth, an SDI system could start an accidental war. According to some Pentagon officials, it would have to react so fast to answer a Soviet ICBM launch that it could only work if its operations were automatic. It is not inconceivable that a space-based computer could make a mistake and fire away, and no human being would be able to stop it in time.

Fifth, the Soviets would inevitably respond to these threats by building up their offensive forces, for they would have no choice but to plan on overcoming the system by sheer numbers. SDI, therefore, would inevitably escalate the arms race, a risky proposition in its own right. Finally, if we pursue SDI, the Soviets will invariably build their own defensive system. As Albert Einstein said of the atomic bomb, "There are no secrets"; it is pure folly to think the Soviets could not reproduce the technology, one way or another, soon after we developed it. Once they have in place a massive defense system, all these destabilizing factors will work both ways, and 'Star Wars' will become a reality.

A ground-based terminal defense would pose none of



these threats. Ground-based interceptor missiles would be no more threatening to satellites or Soviet silos than any current offensive weapon system, and they would be under the control of human officers who would have plenty of time to react to potential attacks. The system would be completely incapable of defending cities, so the Soviets could be confident in their ability to retaliate for any foreseen American attack. And if the Soviets developed a defensive system like ours? All the better, for they would then be more confident of the survivability of their ICBM forces, and hence less likely to attack preemptively out of fear. The possibility of a Soviet point defense should only bother us if we are planning on launching a successful first strike, which, one would hope, we are not.

Opponents of strategic defense argue that even a limited hard-point defense would be destabilizing, since such a system would be, in Soviet eyes, indistinguishable from a nationwide population defense. This fear is groundless, particularly if the system is installed in conjunction with a bilateral agreement regulating its capabilities. For, first of all, it is possible to impose a verifiable limit on the strength and range of defense radars (we reached such an agreement in the ABM Treaty). A defense system cannot protect targets outside the range of its radars, so mutually-agreed-upon limits on range would answer Soviet fears that our point defense system was actually a nationwide population defense system.

Also, virtually all American ICBM sites are in midwestern or western states, so a limited point defense could not conceivably protect our Eastern and Southern population centers. Finally, it is simply impossible to protect cities adequately, as the Soviets surely know. As arms control expert Thomas Schelling put it, "...cities are soft, unconcealable, and almost certainly unprotectable no matter how successfully ballistic missiles may be fended off, there being such a multitude of alternative means of wartime delivery or prewar positioning." The Soviets would thus see point defenses for what they are: a contribution to deterrence.

Limited defense is also much more compatible with arms control than is SDI. The President's dream, in fact, is a nightmare for arms controllers. Because SDI requires the Soviets to build up their offensive forces so as to counter it, it will dash any hope we might have for the reduction or even limitation of offensive nuclear weaponry. The failure of the Reykjavik summit should provide ample proof of this fact. Furthermore, if fully developed, SDI would represent a blatant violation and an utter abandonment of the ABM Treaty, which was designed precisely to prohibit such population-defense systems. The ABM Treaty is by most

accounts the most significant arms control agreement to date; West German Foreign Minister Hans-Dietrich Genscher has called it "the Magna Carta of arms control." All but the most hawkish analysts agree that the control of both offensive and defensive arms in some form is in our interest, and SDI will be fatal to these efforts.

Limited point defense, however, could co-exist with arms control, and might even enhance it. An American system would provide no incentive for either side to build up its offensive forces, so, assuming both sides were interested, the limitation of offensive weapons would be within reach.

The ABM Treaty poses a greater problem, for even a limited point defense would in fact violate it. But there is good reason to believe the ABM Treaty could be amended so as to allow limited systems on both sides; it would even be strengthened by amendment. When the treaty was signed in 1972, neither side was strongly opposed to the defense of ICBM silos. Rather, as Thomas Schelling writes, "Antiballistic missiles at that time were thought of primarily as for area defense of populations, not for point defense of military targets." Robert McNamara, President Johnson's Secretary of Defense, first conceived of limiting defensive systems as a means to insure that each side would retain the ability to retaliate for any attack. He did not consider that in time this vital ability would be threatened not only by SDI-like population defenses but also by offensive missiles in a counterforce mode. As Schelling points out, "The ABM Treaty signed in 1972 had one characteristic that was incompatible with its philosophy but was probably a political necessity. The Treaty was intended to preserve the efficacy of retaliatory forces by keeping them from being degraded by enemy defenses.... But ballistic missile defenses could also be used to protect military hard targets...."

Schelling therefore recommends amendment of the treaty: "It was a flaw in the ABM Treaty that 'good' ABM (protecting missiles) was disallowed along with 'bad' ABM (protecting cities). . . A partial reversal of the ban to permit defense of retaliatory weapons would bring us back to the McNamara spirit." The ABM Treaty, then, should not be regarded as sacrosanct, but the *principle* behind it should.

The treaty itself would not be hard to amend. It currently allows each side to protect one site but goes into intricate detail to insure that the defenses of that site are not upgraded to become a large area defense of the kind contemplated in SDI. The limited point defense here envisioned could be legalized simply by expanding the number of allowed sites to include the bulk of each side's ICBM forces but maintaining the strict insurances against possible upgrading. It is unclear whether the Soviets would agree to this amendment, but they might be persuaded to do so if we gave them assurances against what they really fear — SDI. In other words, the US would specifically renounce its 'broad interpretation' of the treaty and tighten up the treaty's language against space-based systems. The two sides in effect would reach a grand compromise in which they renounced destabilizing population defenses but began a jointly-managed transition to defensive as well as offensive deterrence. The result would be an even better ABM Treaty, one that both sides could live with for years to come. Besides, the purpose of the ABM Treaty is to enhance deterrence, and if our ICBM forces are allowed to become increasingly vulnerable to a Soviet first strike, deterrence will be dangerously weakened, treaty or no treaty.

Finally, a limited strategic defense could avoid the divisive effect SDI is now having on the NATO alliance. Our European allies are understandably perturbed that their American partners hope to hide behind an astrodome defense that does not include them. To us, it may look like security; to them, it appears that we are decoupling our security from theirs, leaving them to the wolves. Moreover, they fear the program will derail the arms control efforts underway in Geneva. But a limited defense of military targets would not offend them: it would indicate that we are all in the same boat, all vulnerable to Soviet attack. Our assured ability to retaliate for Soviet aggression, however, would improve their security as well as ours. It is telling that, while our European allies are extremely skeptical about SDI, they supported the limited Safeguard ABM program of the early 1970s.

One caveat is in order: even the best strategic defense system will be destabilizing if it is not implemented carefully. As the United States moves towards a limited point defense, our timing will determine whether it will provoke a hostile Soviet response. A group of Republican legislators led by Rep. Jack Kemp have urged immediate deployment of a limited defense as a prelude to a complete population defense, and Secretary Weinberger recently endorsed the idea. This proposal should be rejected, for two reasons. The first is that Kemp and Weinberger neglect the vital difference between point defense and population defense. Although they see their proposed system largely as a defense of our ICBM forces, they intend also for it to represent an embryonic population defense, or, in their language, 'peace shield.' It would include space-based 'kinetic kill weapons' able to strike Soviet missiles in their 'boost-phase,' which would be destabilizing for the reasons outlined earlier. In building a good point defense, we should actively avoid any systems that could be construed as population defenses.

The Kemp proposal would be provocative not only because it would contain such systems but also because it would be seen by the Soviets as an interim step towards a full 'astrodome' defense. Faced with an explicit American intention to upgrade the system to a nationwide population defense, the Soviets would have no choice but to build up their offensive forces and intensify their own strategic defense research — no matter how inoffensive our initial system itself. To avoid this escalation of the arms race, we should accompany any point defense with an explicit disavowal of plans for a future population defense. Preferably, we should precede deployment of the system with amendment of the ABM Treaty, as suggested earlier. Even Secretary of State George Schultz and the Joint Chiefs of Staff oppose the early deployment scheme, and President Reagan has thusfar been reluctant to endorse it.

A second obstacle to the implementation of any strategic defense system is the ABM Treaty itself. To build a point defense (or SDI, for that matter), the United States must find a way around the strictures of the treaty. The Administration has a novel answer to this problem: the so-called 'broad interpretation' of the treaty text. Devised by State Department legal adviser Abraham Sofaer, the new interpretation would allow the development and testing, but not the deployment, of defensive technologies that did not yet exist when the treaty was signed in 1972.

Leaving aside the question of whether this interpretation is legally valid, the United States should not adopt it. The Soviets have repeatedly rejected Sofaer's formula, and they would see its adoption as a complete abandonment of the treaty. The result would be an incensed Soviet leadership that would press ahead with plans to counter any American defensive system. Re-interpretation, then, is no better than scuttling the agreement altogether.

While the Administration sees its new interpretation as a short-term way to get around the treaty for testing purposes, it realizes that, over the long-term, even the broadened treaty will prevent deployment of SDI. So the American delegation in Geneva is currently trying to amend the treaty so that it will expire in ten years. Like the 'broad interpretation,' this ploy is ill-advised. If the treaty is allowed to expire, there will remain no constraints on Soviet development of a nationwide population defense; and, as Secretary Weinberger has admitted, a Soviet 'Star Wars' system would pose a grave threat to our security. It is therefore in our interests to preserve the ABM Treaty, amending it to allow the construction of limited point defenses on both sides, but retaining its essential principle: the ban on destabilizing population defenses.

A limited strategic defense would contribute to American security and to the prevention of nuclear war. It would avoid the destabilizing features of SDI, and it could be reconciled with efforts for the meaningful limitation and reduction of strategic nuclear weapons. Why then has it caught on only with Richard Perle, Senator Sam Nunn, and a handful of other sophistocates?

The answer lies, of course, in the appeal of the President's dream. Ronald Reagan dreams of a day when nuclear weapons will be "impotent and obsolete," when relations between the superpowers will no longer be governed by the principle of 'Mutually Assured Destruction,' or MAD. It is an appealing dream. Combined with the ever-present American faith that technology can ultimately solve all problems, it is the stuff of which defense policies can be made. It follows from this dream that a limited defense of our retaliatory forces is somehow inadequate. Some go so far as to say that it would be immoral to protect missiles but not people.

But President Reagan has it wrong. MAD is not a policy that can simply be cast away, and it is not a technological obstacle that can be bypassed if we just put our American know-how to work on it. As Robert McNamara has written, "...mutual assured destruction is not, as some have alleged, an immoral policy. Mutual assured destruction — the vulnerability of each superpower to the awesome destructive power of nuclear weapons — is not a policy at all. It is a fact of life."

The American people will not easily accept this fact. They may not be excited by the idea of defending ICBM silos to strengthen MAD. But that is no excuse for bad policy: it is the duty of government to educate them, so they can make an informed choice. If our imperfect system of nuclear deterrence cannot by transformed, it can at least be strengthened and made more secure. A limited strategic defense will no doubt reinforce MAD, but it will make the world a safer place. It is time that we stop judging strategic defense by how it lives up to the President's dream, and start judging it by how it faces up to reality.❑

The Case for Fraternities at Yale

Joseph Smith

"Resolved: There is no place for fraternities or sororities at Yale."

So read the resolution last year when the Yale Political Union hosted one of its most well–attended student debates in recent history. That debate, much dinner conversation, and a host of *Daily News* editorials later, Yalies continue to argue the merits of fraternities and sororities, and the implications of their resurgence in undergraduate life at Yale.

The trend is one of national scale. After a nearly devastating lack of student interest during the 1960's and 1970's, fraternities and sororities have recuperated and reestablished themselves in American college life. Why have attitudes toward fraternities changed? They have changed because students have changed. Undergraduates today are simply more conservative, more interested in the value of traditional college life than what the campus unrest of the 60's and 70's could offer. Anti–war protests are out; ROTC is in. President Reagan is in on campus, too. And fraternities are back.

Yale, as usual, is unusual. Yale remains among the few schools where sitting in and speaking out are still fashionable. But Yalies, too, have retreated from the real heydays of campus protest. Here, too, membership in fraternities and sororities has risen sharply in recent years and continues to grow.

As with just about anything at Yale, people are debating the issue. Discussion is good, but this particular discussion lacks balance in two ways. First, attacks on fraternities and sororities have been consistent enough to overwhelm pro–fraternity efforts on the editorial pages. Fraternities and sororities have been caught on the defensive. As a result, those favoring fraternities spend most of their time scribbling out quarter–or half–page letters to the editor, packed with refutation against specific anti–fraternity articles or editorials. The ball has stayed on one side of the court.

Worse yet, because anti–fraternity sentiments have been relatively vacuous ("sororities are just ditzy girls," for example; or "fraternities are just excuses to get drunk"), the responses have been on a similar level ("sororities are not just groups of ditzy girls;" "fraternities are not just excuses to get drunk"). Hence the second component of the unbalanced discussion: Yale's student body has come to view these petty points as the pivotal concerns in the fraternity issue.

Contrary to what these editorial exchanges suggest, the issue of fraternities at Yale poses seriously debatable questions, at times tapping even the most fundamental issues—the role of higher education in the United States, or the role of community in American life. These questions certainly transcend instances of ditziness or drunkenness; and likewise, the discussion of fraternities at Yale should not remain unbalanced. It is time to aggressively and comprehensively defend the idea of fraternities at Yale: the motivations for forming them, the reasons for joining them, and the rationale for embracing their presence on our campus.

The approach offered here is simple. First examine what college life should be about, with emphasis on the history of American college life. Then, assess Yale's success in the area of college life, and see what fraternities have to offer where Yale might be found deficient. The case is made independent of particulars, so the value fo fraternities at Yale can be established at a more essential level. Thus the goal is to promote the idea of fraternities at Yale, not necessarily any specific fraternities at Yale.

First things first: once upon a time, when a college

Joseph Smith is a junior in Berkeley College and a member of Sigma Chi.

education meant a liberal education focused on the classics and aimed at comprehensive development of the student, Yale was truly a college. Today, however, Yale is a university, and its collegiate features are ever less clear. An interesting article on this subject, authored by Dean Mark B. Ryan of Jonathan Edwards College, appeared recently in *Prism*, Yale's new philosophy tabloid. In the article, Dean Ryan distinguishes what he terms "college values" from what he calls "university values." "University values honor research and specialized scholarship; College values, teaching and general education," writes Ryan, "the former aim to develop fields, the latter to develop students."

Specific to Yale's history, Ryan cites the Reorganization of 1919 as an important turning point. The Reorganization took power from Yale College and gave it to the academic departments of Yale University; the quality of faculty and curriculum was inevitably affected. In Ryan's words, the change, "ensured a faculty whose members considered themselves primarily as investigators, and only secondarily as educators." Ryan's particular concern today, is that the trend toward stronger and stronger university values may seriously threaten the residential college system, which he ranks among Yale's most successful attempts to retain college values.

In a less direct but similarly disposed article in last Fall's *Scrutiny* magazine, author Michael Lind summarizes the historical development of the university in America:
The Germanization of American higher education meant the replacement of gentlemen teachers by industrious, indeed industrialized, scholars. Professionalization, and the dissemination of the German (*not* traditionally American) concepts of *Lernenfreiheit* and *Lehrenfreiheit* —freedom to learn and freedom to teach unchecked by the community—turned universities from finishing schools for the well-heeled into research institutes often only peripherally concerned with teaching, and hostile to the community values colleges were once expected to inculcate.

Lind's mention of community values bears consideration, for a traditional college education is little more than preparation for citizenship, for living an ethically good life. Much of the erosion of community values at Yale came with the drastic increase in undergraduate enrollment alone. Especially in the early twentieth century, observers expressed concern that Yale was becoming too big and consequently too competitive to maintain a sense of community. *Yale's Residential Colleges: The First Fifty Years*, the book published in 1983 to commemorate the college system's golden anniversary, cites these concerns as catalysts to Yale's accepting the idea of a quadrangle plan specifically designed to restore community in Yale life.

Thomas Gergin, the book's author, notes that Nathan Hale's class numbered only 36 in 1773; and that class size reached 1900 by 1920. Such large classes made competition for sports letters, position on the mastheads of the *News* and the *Record*, and positions in senior societies, increasingly fierce. "As the country grew so did Yale," remarks Gergin,"and by the mid nineteenth century it was difficult to maintain the earlier sense of comraderie among all citizens of the republic."

Gergin's reference to the American Republic is by no means extraneous. Traditional college values in America reflect traditional American values in general. Many tend to consider, without much second thought, the American ideal to be one of rampant individualism, perhaps even libertarianism. Today's universities, and Yale in particular, offer environments conducive to this view, environments where the individual must prevail. People destroy one another's projects to assure their standing in classes. Students compete like mad to enter Yale, and competition for positions in graduate schools, professional schools, and Wall Street firms lurks just around the corner.

Liberty has nearly vanquished fraternity. The community–minded values of old face a new, threatening American temperament. The colonists and the framers of the Constitution would certainly regret this development. The men who built Connecticut Hall, in fact, might be the most alarmed, Why? Because the notion of the common good—so prevalent in the writings and especially the sermons of colonial times and the late eighteenth century in America—has nearly vanished. It has been trounced by individualism, competition, and what might best be termed "creeping libertarianism."

Community is hard pressed for survival as a litigious society embeds itself even deeper in contract law, appealing to courts of law for intervention right down to the family level. Contrary to the contemporary trend, American social and political institutions derive more from Aristotle than from Locke; they rightfully emphasize community more than the individual. Aristotle's conception of personhood—that to be fully human is to live in a *polis*, to be a social and political creature—pervades early American discussions of citizenship and public virtue, and it pervades the whole concept of a liberal education, of truly collegiate life.

What has this social history to do with fraternities' comeback today? The link is direct: fraternity is in essence what America and American colleges once stood for. Consider Phi Beta Kappa the paradigmatic example. Founded at William and Mary in 1776, the first American Greek–letter society explicitly ranks morality among its concerns, emphasizing the use of knowledge for the public good.

At Yale today, these resurfacing undergraduate organizations evidence resurfacing undergraduate concerns. With the most recent appeals to the Woodward Report—Yale's carte blanche, free speech policy—the student body has been forced to endure not only one student's posting his malicious satire of some members of the community, but also the public display of a number of pornographic posters. The Woodward Report protects these acts, which otherwise would be considered offensive attacks on the community.

Fraternity, community and the sense of some common good are all in danger at Yale, and fraternities are trying to save them. Fraternities, of course, are not alone in this battle. Yale College itself strives to effect the traditional American ideal of college life. Examples abound: from those less apparent, like not calculating grade point averages; to those more grand, like preserving its residential college system with all the components—residential fellows, freshman counselors, Deans and Masters, intramural teams, etc. Such efforts produce community; they provide the social structures that facilitate full personal development of the student. The repeated emphasis on the value of a liberal arts education that seeks no end but itself caps the college's efforts at preserving traditional college life.

Yale University, as distinct from Yale College, is also well known for preserving respect for the college component of its system of schools. This fact is perhaps best evidenced by the frequent complaints of graduate and professional

students about the lack of attention afforded them by the university. Yale University prides itself on the college, and college life is much better for it. Comparable universities certainly do worse.

Despite all the successes Yale achieves in the area of college life, Yale is far from triumph. To a certain degree, as Dean Ryan notes in his *Prism* article, the faults come in the university's failing to wholeheartedly support the residential colleges. But problems also appear where theory must confront reality. Even the most devoted residential college fellows, for example, could not have the time to become acquainted with 300 or 400 students. With busy schedules, in fact, it would take intense effort to know even a fraction of a college's students.

With Connecticut's recent alcohol restrictions, freshman counselors have become burdened with the dual role of friend and authority. At last report, freshman counselors were under instructions to seize kegs discovered on the Old Campus. Community values are undermined, it should be agreed, when the Yale College Dean's Office orders some students to confiscate other students' property.

Even on a more general level, Yale College remains pressured to maintain a distinctly collegiate identity within such a high–brow university. Intramural teams and residential colleges—even when zealously supported by the university—cannot stop Yale University from hiring scholars before teachers.

Can fraternities pick up where the residential colleges leave off? Can fraternities fight off university priorities and restore a truly collegiate sense of fraternity on campus? The possibility seems worth exploring. First, consider a more analytical definition of *fraternity*, like one offered by John Rawls in *A Theory of Justice*. Rawls writes of the "natural meaning of fraternity: namely, ...not wanting to have greater advantages unless this is to the benefit of others who are less well off." He cites the family as a natural body displaying this principle of fraternity. Aristotle likewise cites the family as evidence for considering human life unfulfilled without social relations.

Fraternities can help push Yale's campus mood toward the Rawlsian ideal of fraternity, toward a certain *esprit de corps*. Fraternities are, after all, friendships for the sake of friendship. Not only are they likely to significantly bolster community spirit; they are, in fact, the institutions best suited for the task. Yale has become a largely factionalized campus—politically, socially, racially. The residential college system was created when Yale was much less diverse, so there is no guarantee that it can solve these relatively new problems. Overcrowding and lack of thorough attention from the university often take the blame for all failings of Yale's residential system, but some problems may simply demand more than what the residential colleges have to offer.

The colleges do not necessarily have fraternity or community first in mind, and they cannot be expected to pursue these concerns at all times. While community spirit is a component of the college system, considerations of housing coordination, meal service, maintenance, academic regulation, and the like necessarily challenge social concerns for priority. Fraternities, on the other hand, stand for community as a primary, unmitigated ideal. Fraternities offer more vigorous attention to what ails social life at Yale: the lack of fraternity.

Most compelling, the rate at which fraternities are being formed and joined evidences conscious student pursuit of a more determined community spirit. Less abstract evidence supports the more lofty talk of Rawlsian terminology. Consider just a few points. Fraternities provide fora for peer counseling, where someone seeking counsel does not have to talk with strangers or superiors. Furthermore, fraternities offer a completely accessible kind of friendship, not one dependent on members' sharing specific interests or skills. And fraternities necessarily replace raging ambition with an all–for–one–and–one–for–all attitude. In these very concrete ways, fraternities supplement the residential colleges and edify the Yale community. These efforts should be welcomed by all Yale students.

In closing, consider the frequency with which Yale is attacked for just about anything, be it dining hall food or investment policy. Now, when Yale's sense of community is suffering and fraternities are trying to do something about it, why has the status quo, anti–fraternity attitude been so steadfast? Where are the forces of change, the rallies for the cause?

Recalling the national trend of renewed support for fraternities and sororities, the answer may lie not at Yale College, but everywhere else. Yale is a paradise in many ways, from academic quality to architectural splendor. What Yale likes least is that Yale, at an essential level, is not so unusual. Student concerns are quite similar, and solutions to problems may prove strikingly ordinary.

The resurgence of fraternities exemplifies an ordinary solution to a common concern. Like other student bodies, Yale's has suffered the same undesirable fallout from campus unrest in the 1960's and 1970's. And like their counterparts at almost every other university in the nation, many Yale undergraduates have decided to affirm their belief in more traditional college values by "going Greek."

In yet one more arena Yale College meets reality, and people are nervous. Witness the fury each Spring at University Career Services: if there's one thing that frightens Yale undergraduates, it's reality.❑

Glasnost for What Purpose?

Eric Liu

Editor's note—the following article was written earlier in the Spring and does not attempt to report the most recent developments in the Soviet Union. It is rather an analysis of the motivations behind the reform policies of General Secretary Gorbachev.

One expert on the Soviet Union has said that Soviet policymaking and practical work have been overcome by "conservative sentiments, a tendency to brush aside everything that does not fit into conventional patterns and an unwillingness to come to terms with outstanding socio-economic problems." These words are neither exceptionally frank nor unprecedented—until one considers who this expert is. In the weeks since he presented this indictment to the Central Committee of the Communist Party, Soviet General Secretary Mikhail Gorbachev has made several moves which have shocked the world, heightened its expectations, and distorted its perceptions. Attacking the Party's structural shortcomings and the vested interest which preserves them, he has proposed multi–candidate and secret ballot elections at the local, provincial, and republic levels, and he has released 140 political prisoners, with a comparable number of cases under consideration.

That Soviet society is undergoing a significant transition is thus evident. What is not so clear, however, are Gorbachev's motives in his call for revision and restructuring. And it is here that observers must be extremely realistic: an opportunity to clothe national interest in humanitarianism is as easy for the United States to misinterpret as it is difficult for Gorbachev to pass up. The media hype over this relative democratization has dangerously obscured the fact that given the rigid framework of cold war competition, Gorbachev's shift in rhetoric is made out of *pragmatic national interest*. His adjustment is far less an abandonment of the contemporary Soviet political system than it is a fortification for future conflict in the international arena.

Gorbachev's policy of *glasnost*, or openness, has certainly consisted of some dramatic moves. In his January 27 speech, he linked the economic atrophy of the Brezhnev era to stifling bureaucratization and abuse of the socialist system, decrying the social corrosion it has engendered. As the effectiveness of central economic planning was subverted by provincial interests and myopic implementation, he argued, "irresponsibility was preserved and diverse bureaucratic rules and instructions were devised. Day-to-day practical activity was replaced with rule by decree."

Citing these systemic failures, Gorbachev has called for secret balloting and a choice of candidates in the election of party officials—hinting that "democratization should also apply to the formation of central leading bodies of the party." In past elections, candidates who were handpicked by national party leaders ran unopposed, and were endorsed by a show of hands. Gorbachev proposed the broadening of electoral districts "to give full scope to the expression of the will of all Communists," and he also suggested convening a party congress next year, the first of its kind since 1941, to review organizational party changes.

The urgency in Gorbachev's words was matched within weeks by the release of first 51, and then a total of 140 political prisoners. This was the first realization of his structural reform rhetoric: the pardons were granted under two decrees issued on February 2 and 9 which overrode Article 70 of the Criminal Code, one of the most potent means of crushing "anti–Soviet agitation and propaganda" in the hands of the government.

This rapid-fire democratization has been extremely well–received in the Western press. But the West and the United States in particular must understand that the expansion of civil liberties is *incidental* to Gorbachev's

Eric Liu is a freshman in Timothy Dwight College.

purposes. His call for a less irresponsible, less corrupt government is progressive in nature, but it is directed towards traditional goals—the streamlining of an inefficient social-economic machine and the consolidation of his own power bloc—which will place the Soviet Union in a strategically favorable position with respect to the United States as the cold war enters the 21st century.

Some analysts of this situation have wrongly focused far more on political than on economic change. In the past weeks, while headlines heralded the release of scores of dissidents and the call for a party revamping, a new law was quietly implemented. This law loosens central economic authority and gives state enterprises greater autonomy, by which, according to *Pravda*, "socialist enterprises will conduct economic management at their own expense and ensure that they pay their own way and turn a profit." Another statute was simultaneously published which sanctions joint economic ventures with the West, based on foreign investment. But these efforts at *perestroika*, or restructuring of the economy, have gone comparatively unnoticed. Ironically, they strike much closer to the heart of what Gorbachev is trying to achieve than do his well–publicized electoral reform proposals.

These economic moves constitute a major adjustment of such traditional Soviet ideological tenets as centralized planning and the inevitable conflict between capitalism and communism. But Gorbachev is acting pragmatically to revitalize a system which is based on and ultimately dedicated to that ideology. Not unlike Lenin's New Economic Policy and the more recent "Brezhnev Doctrine," *glasnost* is a stage, a flexible means to lead the Soviet Union from the "mature socialist state" that it is now, to true communism. We must understand that the increasingly flexible government which Gorbachev seeks is intended to be *in the service of* a more productive industrial machine. When Gorbachev urged the party to shed the legacy of Stalin and Brezhnev, he spoke with essentially economic interests in mind. During the Brezhnev years, he said, "a need for change was evidently overdue, but it was not realized in the political and practical work of the party and the state."

But whereas his economic reform is a significant and widely applicable departure from standard Marxist doctrine, his political reform constitutes only a nominal loosening in a narrowly limited single-party context. It is true that Gorbachev has made the first group prisoner release since 1953—but the release of prisoners by no means translates into the creation of a legitimate opposition. The introduction of secret balloting into elections where candidates, however many, are still pre–chosen by the party elite, is at best a symbolic shift in the status quo. Indeed, it is easy to see Gorbachev's priorities in reverse. For instance, the December 23 release of dissident Andrei Sakharov, a prominent physicist, was an enormous humanitarian propaganda success. But at the root of this action was national economic self–interest, more than a desire to expand civil liberties. Freeing Sakharov and appealing for him to resume his research creates support from the Soviet intelligentsia, Gorbachev reasons. He hopes that a reinvigorated intelligentsia will spur the internal exchange of ideas and the access to Western technology which are essential for any revitalization of the economy.

Gorbachev's sophisticated use of the American press has widened the gap between intention and perception. In some cases, accounts of the reforms which are supposed to improve the quality of Soviet life were not even reported in the Soviet press. The fact that the mass release of dissidents was publicized only to the West invites suspicion: as the most politically palatable and astute Soviet leader in history, Gorbachev can play our media game and win. And the American press seems implicitly sympathetic to a Soviet leader whose efforts are reminiscent of past leaders, but whose style is much more polished; Nikita Khrushchev and Aleksei Kosygin, in 1956 and 1965 respectively, offered similar plans to revive the party and decentralize the economy, and were eventually defeated. Magazines and newspapers have labeled Gorbachev's plans "breathtaking" and "extraordinary," reporting that the man whom Henry Kissinger called "a totally new Soviet leader" struck Jeane Kirkpatrick as "smart, competent, and well-informed."

Other developments point to the Soviet desire to present an attractive face to the United States: Boris Pasternak's long-banned novel, *Doctor Zhivago*, will be published in Moscow next year; the Kremlin held in February an international forum on a "nonnuclear world" which was attended by Americans from Norman Mailer to Gregory Peck to John Kenneth Galbraith; and Jewish activist Iosif Begun was released later that month. Through the distorting prism of upbeat and laudatory media coverage, these initiatives appear much more substantive than they truly are, and the motives behind them much less selfish.

Analysts who praise the Soviet leader's bold steps, his risk–taking, and his seizing of the political initiative, are absorbed in a doctrine of relative good. Perhaps in the context of Soviet history, Gorbachev is making drastic proposals. But we should not examine his expansion of electoral and civil rights just unto itself. This is no benevolent liberalization, and Gorbachev is certainly not repudiating the benefits of a totalitarian state: democratization, like the growing adaptability of economic policy, is a means and not an end. If, as a Soviet commentator asserts, "the purpose of legal reform is to release energy, initiative, and independence," then the

purpose of this energy is to better compete against the United States. For Soviet intentions of achieving a strategic advantage, if not domination, in the bipolar cold war world, have not changed. Political and economic change is directed towards a leaner and stronger military–industrial system. And systemic efficiency is in turn intended to make the Soviet Union a more formidable geopolitical adversary.

In a February 16 speech, Gorbachev said that the Soviet Union seeks "lasting peace, predictability, and constructiveness" so that it can concentrate on domestic concerns. It would be more accurate to say that he is concentrating on domestic concerns in order to bolster the Soviet ability to create a favorable world stability. Gorbachev's strategy is thus to strengthen the government system and make it "more workable," not to dismantle the party apparatus.

However, as a result of his aspirations for power consolidation, resistance from the potential losers has become a great obstacle. When Gorbachev announced that he wanted to turn the party from a complacent bureaucracy to an instrument for change by "reform from below," he directly challenged the vast administrative stratum of the government to reform or desist. The stultified mid–level bureaucracy has defied or grudgingly heeded his call for economic reform, for the policies they are supposed to implement undercut the very interest they have in institutional excess.

Perhaps even more significantly, Old Guard members of the leadership are resisting Gorbachev's urgent agenda. Thus it is not clear whether some of Gorbachev's proposals are directed simply towards establishing a sufficiently wide power base. Despite the relative speed with which Gorbachev has infused new blood into a static party leadership, standpat holdovers in high–level positions from the 18–year Brezhnev era remain in the majority. In these terms, Gorbachev's call for contested elections appears to be in part a device to get his own people in: it presents a challenge to incumbents who disfavor him.

The most recent plenum of the Central Committee was a telling indicator of resistance of the Old Guard and their ability to force Gorbachev into compromise. The plenum was postponed twice over the promotion of Gorbachev ally Alexander Yakovlev to the policy–making Politburo. Gorbachev managed to secure this position and two others for loyalists in the policy–implementing Secretariat, but he paid the price: the last Brezhnev holdover in the Politburo, Vladimir Shcherbitsky, was not retired, while Gorbachev followers Boris Yeltsin (Moscow party chief) and Anatoly Dobrynin (Ambassador to the U.S.) were bypassed for appointment. Furthermore, the plenum did not specifically endorse any of Gorbachev's reform proposals, giving his electoral initiative only vague approbation. Indeed, throughout his speech on greater political choice, Gorbachev was careful to emphasize that "the principles of party rules should remain unshakable."

Another sign of internal conflict was the sudden security crackdown on small demonstrations for the release of Begun. The action was so inconsistent with Gorbachev's rhetoric that many Kremlinologists speculated that it was the independent work of the KGB, registering opposition to liberalization. Obviously, then, Gorbachev's desire for fresh approaches to party rule translates into a desire to remove those who resist his dominance within the party mechanism.

Nevertheless, Gorbachev's considerable skill as a politician reduces the chances of his going the way of Khrushchev, who was ousted in 1964 for, among other things, his over-liberalization of internal affairs. Mikhail Gorbachev's ability to make deceptively limited moves and his capacity for compromise make it very clear that we should worry less about his domestic resiliency, and more about what geopolitical implications his cry for political and economic restructuring will have. Gorbachev's recent enthusiasm for arms control is another demonstration that it is not his sincerity so much as his motives that we should question. With arms control, the gradual nature of scaling down nuclear forces and the erstwhile heavy Soviet reliance on conventional forces are obvious counterweights to his seeming benevolence. With *glasnost*, how does the Soviet state benefit?

Many of us expect liberalization to mean Americanization, an implicitly deferential acceptance of our institutional values. But as the party infighting shows, and the American media emphasis *belies*, liberalization is not a conciliatory move towards the United States. When we consider the ultimate end which *glasnost* and *perestroika* serve—the creation of a tightly consolidated, internationally formidable, aggressive, and efficient state—liberalization is actually quite the opposite. A misguided view of change in the Soviet Union can hide the fact that there is no inconsistency between domestic flexibility and foreign toughness. And more dangerously, it can create illusions about the cold war rivalry in which we are still entrenched.❑

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The Challenges Facing Soviet Economic Reform

Jontahan Gleklen

A small item in the *New York Times* reported that among the one hundred and forty prisoners released under Mikhail Gorbachev's *glasnost* campaign was a dissident named Lev Timofeev. Timofeev, relatively unknown in the West by the standards of Sakharov, Solzhenitsyn, or Scharansky, was arrested and sentenced in September of 1985 to six years in a labor camp and five years of exile for publishing articles in dissident journals abroad. These articles were not calls for the granting of religious or political rights, but for economic ones. His plan cut to the heart of the Soviet system. What he desired was the end of communism and the reintroduction of capitalism.

The lot of the peasant in Russia has been used as a rallying cry for *Narodniks*, Social Revolutionaries, Communists, and in Timofeev's Soviet Peasants, or, *The Peasant's Art of Starving* it served as the basis for an attack on collectivized agriculture, central planning, bureaucracy, and Soviet power in general. Timofeev published the work in *samizdat* in 1980, long before Mikhail Gorbachev was chosen as General Secretary of the CPSU and embarked on his program of reform. While we have no reason to suspect that Gorbachev has anything other than an orthodox Marxist view of political economy, it seems that Timofeev's release is an indication that the Soviet Government is listening to Timofeev's complaints and maybe even some of his suggestions.

The pivotal issue of the book is that of the NEP, Lenin's New Economic Policy. This program, which allowed limited private enterprise, especially in the agricultural sector of the economy, was Lenin's attempt to temper the hardship that War Communism had imposed during the period of the Russian Civil War. In the early Twenties the new Soviet government had neither consolidated its support nor gained the bureaucratic power that would come with Stalin and would allow it to disregard popular sentiment. It was clear that something had to be done to help the peasants, who could hardly differentiate between the price to be paid under War Communism and exploitation at the hands of capitalists. The NEP was Lenin's response. "We must plainly see that the peasantry is dissatisfied with the form of our relations, that it does not want relations of this type and will not continue to live as it has hitherto...We are sober enough politicians to say frankly: let us reexamine our policy with regard to the peasantry. The state of affairs that has prevailed so far cannot continue." The result was the imposition of taxes instead of the appropriation of produce that was practiced under War Communism. As far as Timofeev and we are concerned, however, it was the opening of the market that was the most important innovation of the NEP.

Though Timofeev reads too much into the NEP, it was never intended to make capitalism a permanent feature of the Soviet Economy, the debates surrounding it provide insights into the problems facing Gorbachev in his quest for reform. The struggle between Gorbachev and the opponents of economic reform mirrors the differences between a Leninist and Stalinist approach to ruling.

There has always been tension between the nascent Soviet free market and orthodox communist economic theory. Introducing the NEP at the 10th Congress of the CPSU in March, 1921, Lenin did not shirk from recognizing the contradictions inherent in allowing a free market while trying to build Communism. "All of us who have studied at least the elements of Marxism know that this exchange and freedom of trade inevitably leads to...a revival of capitalist wage slavery...How can the Communist Party

Jonathan Gleklen is a junior in Davenport College and has travelled in the Soviet Union.

recognize the freedom to trade and accept it? The practical solution to the problem presents many difficulties." It is just those difficulties with which Gorbachev is now trying to deal.

Timofeev's work is a paean to both the free market and the long-suffering Russian peasant. The alleviation of the latter's difficulties, as far as Timofeev is concerned, is possible only through the application of the former. "Ideological inhibitions," he writes, "have smothered economic possibilities and hindered initiative." Timofeev is well aware of the difficulties for the Communist Party involved in allowing the market a role in socialism, and he is all for them. He believes that discussion of "market socialism" is a worthless pastime, and he knows that the highest members of the Communist oligarchy understand this. To accomplish what he wants, the Soviet State seemingly must be destroyed.

The sad state of Soviet collectivized agriculture today is clear. Timofeev claims that according to official records, personal parcels make up only 1.5 to 2% of all cultivated land and use only 10% of the funds devoted to agriculture; yet, they produce up to one-third of all the agricultural products in the Soviet Union. Gorbachev's reforms are an attempt to reconcile the contradictions inherent in "market socialism" without destroying the state. The problems he faces are clear. His statistics are better than Timofeev's, but they lead to the same conclusions. The free market is working; the planned economy is failing. Rather than move to a free market, he must try to reform the planned economy, borrowing the successful practices of the free market without actually becoming one. Lenin saw the problems and challenges of the Socialist system; Gorbachev must now try to conquer them.

While Lenin believed that the free market and the construction of socialism were incompatible, he envisioned the period of the NEP as one in which there could be competition between the two systems. The NEP was then a test of socialism; could they accomplish what the capitalists could without the inherent exploitation involved in capitalism? In one speech Lenin imagined a peasant saying to the communists:

> The capitalists are operating alongside us. They operate like robbers; they make a profit, but they know how to do things. But you you are trying to do it in a new way: you make no profit, your principles are communist, your ideals are splendid; they are written out so beautifully that you should go to heaven while you are still alive. But can you get things done?

Lenin believed that if the Communists could not "get things done" that the new Soviet government would crumble. At the end of the first year of the NEP Lenin reported, "During the past year we showed quite clearly that we cannot run the economy. That is the fundamental lesson. Either we prove the opposite in the coming year or Soviet power will not be able to exist." It is clear that they have *not* proved the opposite in the intervening sixty-five years. As Timofeev wrote, "No economic shock neither economic failure nor the ruin of peasants and workers appears to be capable of shaking the stability of the system." Even the personal fortunes of the rulers and party leaders seem not to depend in the least on economic circumstances. How could Lenin have made such an egregious misjudgment? He did not know of how his successor, Joseph Stalin would entrench the system, making the state stronger through terror and through bureaucracy. As a result of the combination of these two factors, the needs and desires of the people became irrelevant. Where Lenin started and provided the theoretical basis for the Soviet state, Stalin made the state a secure reality. That would be Stalin's contribution to the Soviet system.

It is clear that the NEP was not the introduction of capitalism. The NEP was, according to Lenin as well as Stalin, a temporary fix. Lenin saw the NEP as an orderly retreat in order to link up with the peasant masses, to be followed by a "firm and unswerving march forward with them." What is more important than what Lenin believed, for he would live for only three years after the introduction of the NEP, was what Stalin believed. "NEP is a freedom for private trade within *certain* boundaries," Stalin wrote, "*with the proviso that the role of the state as regulator of the market is guaranteed.*" [Emphasis in the original.] Because of the twin terrors of physical and bureaucratic coercion, Stalin could respond to Bukharin's criticism of collectivization from a position of power, the power to declare something to be the truth, not from a position based in logic. (One wonders how Timofeev would feel about being put in the same boat as Bukharin; politics does make strange bedfellows) "Does this mean that...we are exploiting the peasant?", asked Stalin, "No, it does not." Why not? Stalin had the power to say that was so because, "the very nature of the Soviet regime precludes any sort of exploitations by the state." He did this by having no illusions about what a dictatorship of the proletariat was all about. The Communist Party would play the leading role in the life of the state or the state would not exist. Just what kind of state would be left is clear from the horror of the Purges of the Thirties.

Physical terror largely ended with Stalin's death in 1953, but the bureaucracy is his most lasting legacy. "It is

simply astonishing how easily all the country's economic problems could be solved," Timofeev writes, "if collective and state farms were released from the severe administrative restrictions and prohibitions hampering their economic flexibility." Adam Smith would be proud to hear him say, "the economy is a mechanism where a planned bureaucratic system will creak and grind to a halt without a link to the flywheel of market relations worked out by the whole history of mankind." So much for inculcating the idea that capitalism would be relegated to the scrap heap of history.

If capitalism is truth and Soviet power is based on Communism, the only logical step for Timofeev would be to say that the Soviet regime must eventually perish. In order to gain his release, Timofeev signed a statement pledging that, "I do not intend to harm the Soviet state, not that I have had such an intention before." Yet it is hard to make this jibe with what he has written; he sees Communism as inconsistent with reality, kept in power solely by force: "It is possible to do without the market only within the constructs of Soviet political economics."

Timofeev accepts an almost social-Darwinian view of the market, one which is even more antithetical to the fundamental principles of the Soviet system than the NEP. "When it comes to market relations, a kind of here and fine morals are of no use. The market has its own laws that are objective in nature...The market seller has no soul."

Gorbachev may agree with him. His reforms are an attempt to fulfill Lenin's goal, to pass the peasant's test. Marxism tells him that the workers and peasants cannot be satisfied by the soulless market; history has told him that although the people can be kept in line by terror, this tactic is not in the long-term economic interests of the state. His solution, clearly a Leninist one, is to turn away from Stalin's legacy, to reform the bureaucracy, to make the Soviet system work.

For both Timofeev and Gorbachev it is not only Stalin's terror that relegated the peasants to their poor housing and unfulfilling diets and the economy to definite second-rate status. It is, in Timofeev's words, "the dictatorship of mediocrity's terror of talent." "In our country," Timofeev wrote, "this overwhelming terror has become a governing force." Lenin identified the entrenched bureaucracy, party faithful who have served the party yet know nothing of competition. Lenin commented: "If we take Moscow with its 4,700 Communists in responsible positions, and if we take that huge bureaucratic machine, that gigantic heap, we must ask: who is directing whom?" Stalin, in ensuring Soviet power, at the same time ensured bureaucratic power. The difference between attacking the structure of the state and attacking the state itself vanished through fear, and it is this that Gorbachev is trying to change. An open market became unacceptable not only because of its undesired consequences ("a revival of capitalist wage slavery"), but because it would threaten the bureaucracy, which is synonymous with the state. An open market has little need of administration, a planned one exists only by virtue of its administration.

Under Stalin, that which threatened the bureaucracy was defined as threatening the ideals of the state. All economic growth was not good, only that which, in Stalin's words, "contributes to the dominance of the socialist sector of the national economy over the capitalist sector.", and in saying this the Soviet historians are correct. Because the market threatened the position of all government officials, it could only be tolerated as far as it served the ends of the Soviet state. It is fine as long as it only placates the peasantry, but if it strengthens the peasantry and makes it more politically aware (i.e. gives it a class consciousness) it must be reigned in. That attitude is continued today by the faceless Soviet bureaucrat, looking to safeguard his position, not build the economy. They have adopted Stalin's approach as an excuse; they have instilled fear of disorder and counter-revolution as a guard against reform. Timofeev writes, "We are on a leash just loose enough for us to breathe, nothing more."

Gorbachev and fellow reformers have little stake in the aging, atrophied bureaucracy. They realize that it has stifled innovation and progress, and hope to replace its social control function with more genuine popular support for the leadership. But while they are in the process of doing this they must not lose control of the people, and, even more importantly, they must maintain political control of their party. They must fight bureaucrats who have become accustomed to the Stalinist system of control, who have lost their faith in the ability of the party to govern on the basis of true popular support. But economic independence must not be allowed to transform itself into political independence, it must increase support for the Party.

Gorbachev's speech before the Twenty-Seventh Party Congress showed the dimension of his break with Stalin's bureaucratic system. "It is high time," he said, "to put an end to the practice of ministries and departments exercising petty tutelage over enterprises." The most difficult concept is that of autonomy. The government will still have control over the economy, but this control should not be so great as to stifle initiative. It is a mistake to see in the reforms the beginnings of something approaching a Western European Social Democracy. As Nikolai Ryzhkov, Chairman of the Council of Ministers, said in his speech to the Congress, "Relying on the immutable principle of democratic

centralism, we must continue...the centralized plan governed guidance of the economy -socialism's great gain and essential advantage. In this matter, too, it is apparent that we have 'not lived up to' and will never live up to the hopes of the bourgeois ideologists that we will depart from that fundamental principle."

It remains to be seen whether Gorbachev will be given a chance to try his reforms. The Soviet Union is a much more complicated place than we are often led to believe. A break with the Stalinist legacy, while popular in the West, was the cause of Nikita Khrushchev's downfall and is still dangerous in a place where one can see photos of Stalin taped to the rear windows of cars. In the popular conception, Stalin strengthened the state; Khrushchev weakened it. Gorbachev will only get his chance if he can convince the Soviet public, used to hardship and willing to endure it in times of crisis, that the reforms will strengthen the Soviet state militarily and in the arena of world politics. The Stalinists care little about the daily caloric intake of the peasants or the number of color televisions produced. They must be convinced that the innovation possible in a less structured economy will benefit the military enough to offset the control forfeited with the loss of bureaucratic structure.

Gorbachev must overcome his political obstacles be given a chance to implement all of his reforms. Even if this happens, though, it is not clear that his half-way approach to the market will work well enough to placate the peasants, the Stalinists or Timofeev. In the end it may turn out that Adam Smith was right after all.❑

Bibliographic Note:

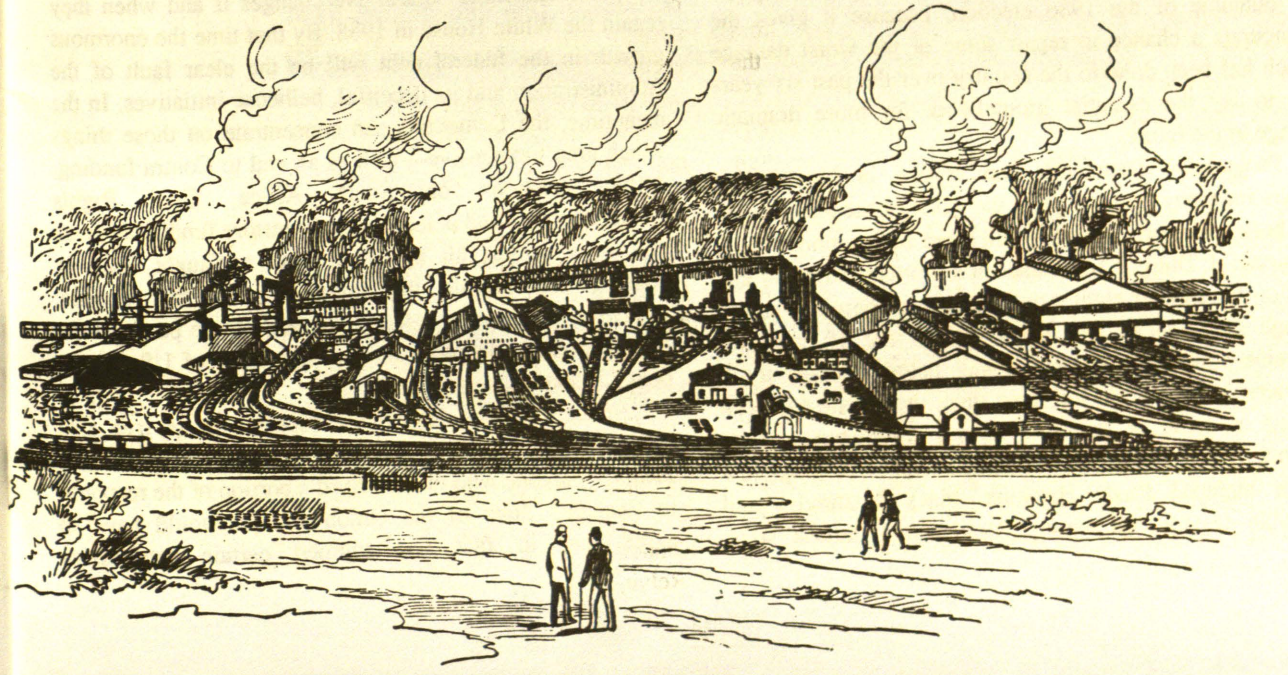
Timofeev's book was edited by Armando Pitasio and Victor Zaslavsky. It was published in New York by the Telos Press in 1985.

The quotations from Lenin were taken from Robert Tucker's *The Lenin Anthology* (New York, 1975). They are from his report to the Tenth Congress of the CPSU in March, 1921 (pp.503-510), and his report to the Eleventh Congress in March, 1922 (pp. 518-533)

The quotations from Stalin were taken from Joseph Stalin's pamphlet, *The Right Deviation in the CPSU* (Bolshevik), in B. Franklin's *The Essential Stalin*, (New York, 1972).

The quotations from General Secretary Gorbachev's speech to the 27th Party Congress were taken from the April, 1986 issue of *Socialism: Theory and Practice*, published by the Soviet Union's Novosti Press Agency.

Nikolai Ryzhkov's speech was taken from a pamphlet published by the Novosti Press Agency Publishing House.



Letters & Comments

To the Editors:

Apparently no one told the 100th Congress of Jon Zasloff's typically cynical assessment of the November election (*YPM* 11/86), namely that "the 1986 election heralds not the destruction of the Reagan revolution, but rather its entrenchment, albeit without some of its harder edges." Congressional ignorance of this pronouncement is extremely fortunate; if the House and Senate had been apprised of the futility of the latter's shift to Democratic control they would have been too demoralized to produce the flurry of progressive proposals, hearings, and bills that have arisen during the past six weeks. [The letter was written this past Winter—Ed.] Even without the vigor of legislative activity, however, some of which may be attributed to the administration's Iran-Contra tailspin, the solid Democratic victory in the Senate would have been sufficient cause for the party's celebration, despite its governorships. Politely ignoring Mr. Zasloff's yawns, Americans should care about the outcome of the 1986 election, because it gives the Democrats a chance to repair some of the worst damage which has been done to the country over the past six years and to lay the essential groundwork for more dramatic change in the future.

Progressive Democrats can rejoice in November's results for many reasons. First, the worst of the Reagan tide has been stemmed. Not only will there be no more Daniel Manions, if Thurgood Marshall and William Brennan can hold on for another eight months to a year there is a strong change that Reagan will have made a net of only two Supreme Court appointments—well below average for a two–term president. At the same time, the Senate has been purged of some of its most vicious reactionaries—only Idaho's Symms remains from the ultra–right wrecking crew which included Paula Hawkins, Mack Mattingly, and Jeremiah Denton, all among Reaganism's darkest stars. Perhaps their replacements are not liberal enough to suit Mr. Zasloff: it is a safe bet that Bob Graham and Wyche Fowler will not be spearheading the fight for comprehensive national health insurance this term. Nonetheless, these men are infinitely preferable to their opponents, and their victories represent an important rejection of a narrow, hateful brand of nationalism by a middle–of–the road constituency. It is true that the Senate's shift will not immediately translate into a progressive's dream, but there is a great deal of potential for this Congress if, in two years, it is coupled with a strong Democratic President. The New Deal was not floor–led by people like Ted Kennedy.

Yet there is much more to this victory than tossing out the bad guys. November opened the door for the Democratic Party to shed, once and for all, the offensive "tax and spend" label which gave Ronald Reagan so much mileage over his first six years in office. To do so is crucial if Democrats wish to make more substantive changes if and when they regain the White House in 1988. By that time the enormous growth in the federal debt will be the clear fault of the Administration and its deceitful, bellicose initiatives. In the meantime, the Democrats can concentrate on those things which aren't expensive—such as an end to Contra funding, stiffer sanctions on South Africa, Civil Rights refurbishment—and at least begin to restore funding in areas that were hardest hit by the Reagan onslaught, such as housing. To belittle the importance of this agenda, following six years of relentless attack on the poor, on the rights of minorities, and on the rationality of US foreign policy is sour grapes.

Concerning the leadership question, it is true that Robert Byrd is not as dynamic or imaginative as Mr. Zasloff—anyone who viewed Byrd's portion of the response to Reagan's State of the Union address would have to agree—and in fact has stymied certain progressive

Democrats. It is also true that the Senate Democrats are not sufficiently cohesive. However, the urgency of this Congress for the Democratic Party and the strong, energetic leadership of the new House Speaker Jim Wright will minimize the impact of these problems. Democrats in the Senate, as well as everywhere else, have learned that they have got to cooperate unless they want another four to eight years of Republican leadership. Evidence that the Democratic caucus has gotten its act together in support of a legitimate, progressive agenda abound. Already the House has taken action on a measure providing emergency funds for shelters for homeless people, and, in a resounding vote, joined with Republicans in overriding President Reagan's veto of the Clean Water Act. Still, Mr. Zasloff will probably protest that the former example is a late, inadequate response to a horrendous problem, that the latter is largely pork barrel, and that neither is fundamentally liberal—and he might be right. However, let's wait until we see what happens with maternity and illness leave, catastrophic health insurance, legislative overturn of Grove City, and mandated adherence to Salt II limits before we whine and lament the ideological credentials of Democratic Senators and the significance of the 1986 election that returned them to power.

William Kincaid '88
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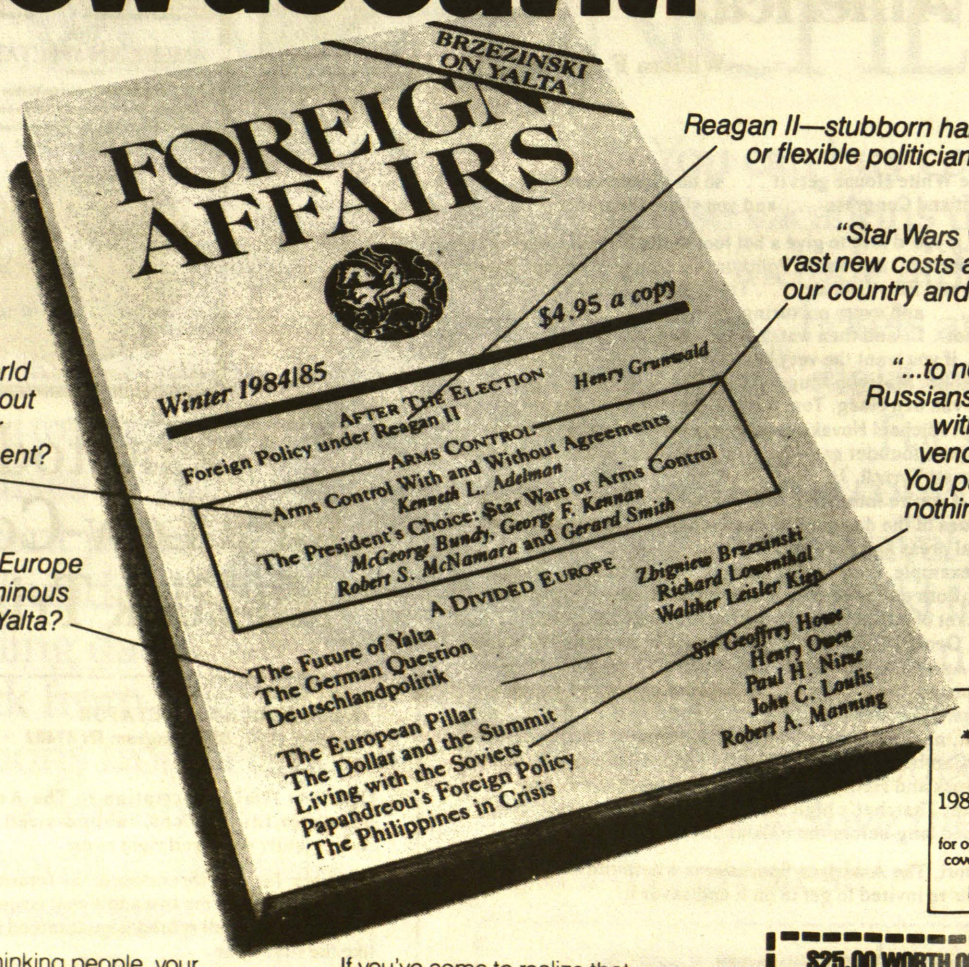

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